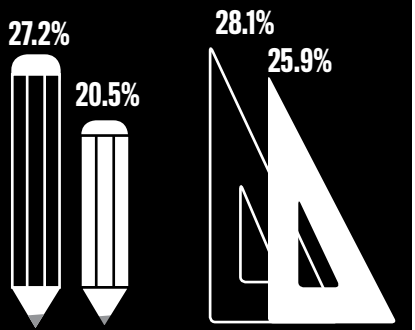
ASER 2022

THE KEY LEARNINGS

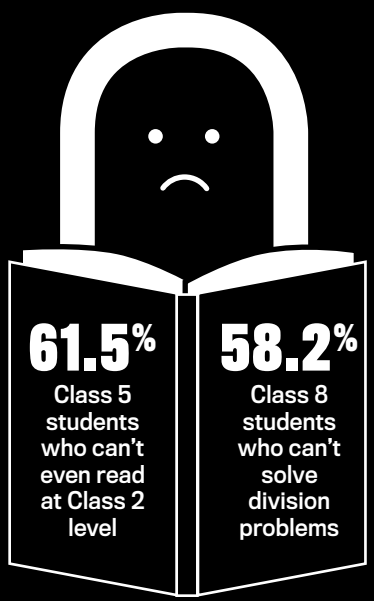
The pandemic and lockdown seem to have affected learning negatively among children enrolled in government schools across rural India. The *Annual Status of Education Report 2022*, released in Jan. 2023, gives us some troubling pointers:



FOUNDATIONAL LITERACY
Class 3 students able to read at least Class 2 level

FOUNDATIONAL NUMERACY
Class 3 students able to do at least subtraction

☐ 2018 ■ 2022



Note: *The nationwide survey covered 699,597 children (aged 3-16) across 19,060 villages in all 616 rural districts*

Graphic by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY

By Amitabh Srivastava

Bihar's political waters, prone to frequent cross-currents and shifting of course as it is, look set to encounter yet another little sinkhole—call it a revolt within a revolt. Chief Minister Nitish Kumar has asked party leader Upendra Kushwaha to "quit the Janata Dal (United) if he so wishes", but the latter refuses to comply, arguing that he cannot leave without "getting his due share". It was only in March 2021 that the 62-year-old former Union minister had merged his Rashtriya Lok Samta Party (RLSP) with the JD(U)—staging his second homecoming, one that now looks likely to be much more short-lived than his first one, in 2009-13.

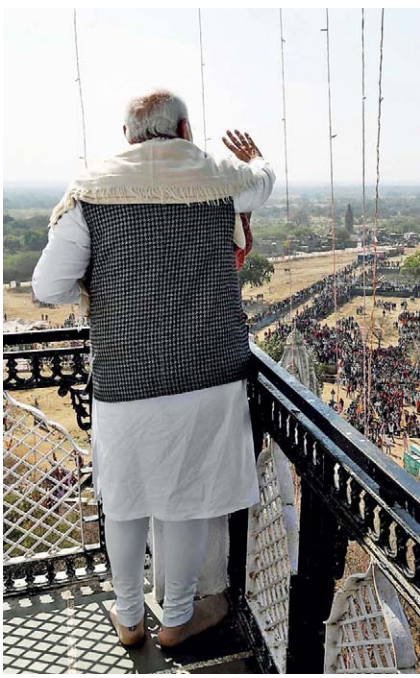
JD(U) sources say Kushwaha fancied himself as a successor to Nitish, but the idea didn't get much traction in the party, hence the dissenting note. He now holds the post of JD(U) parliamentary board president, and for all purposes is No. 3 after Nitish and party president Rajiv Ranjan Singh a.k.a. Lalan Singh. But it seems this wasn't enough, and Kushwaha was left peeved by two things: not being included in the state cabinet, and Nitish's decision to promote RJD leader Tejashwi Yadav as his possible successor as CM.

If Nitish had welcomed Kushwaha, it was largely because it had the potential to reunify the Kurmis and Kushwahas (Koeris), who together constitute about 12 per cent of Bihar's population. Since the 1990s, when Nitish first challenged Lalu Prasad and his Muslim-Yadav vote base, it has been the unity of these closely ranked and often hyphenated caste blocs—known as 'Luv-Kush' in Bihar's political lexicon—that has kept the JD(U) supremo strong. The hope was the axis would strengthen with Kushwaha's entry, but the initial warmth soon dissipated, especially after Nitish dumped the BJP to form a government

RAJASTHAN

EITHER/OR? BOTH, SAYS BJP

By Rohit Parihar



With Rajasthan going to the polls this year, it continues to receive special attention from Prime Minister Narendra Modi. However, instead of offering overtly caste-specific inducements, the BJP is wooing communities through promises of development and gestures honouring their cultural and religious practices. On January 30, it was announced that Modi would inaugurate the Sohna-Dausa stretch of the Delhi-Mumbai Expressway on February 12. If the PM does inaugurate it in Dausa, the venue won't be without significance: it was the Lok Sabha constituency that sent Congress leader Sachin Pilot to the Lok Sabha for the first